

Severe Bleeding Response

A quick reminder after recognized STOP THE BLEED® or equivalent instructor-led training—not a substitute for hands-on practice.

× DANGER — STOP NOW

Life-threatening bleeding is an emergency. Call 911 or your local emergency number now. Do not delay emergency activation to read this handout. Follow the dispatcher's instructions.

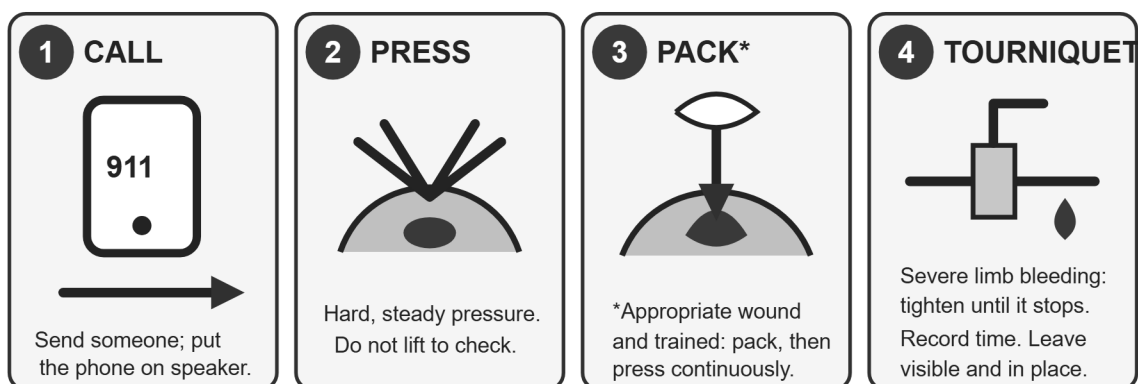
△ CAUTION — PREVENT HARM

DRAFT—DO NOT DISTRIBUTE FOR USE. A clinician or certified bleeding-control instructor must review the words and diagram before this handout moves beyond draft.

RECOGNIZE AND ACT

Suspect life-threatening bleeding when blood flows continuously or spurts, pools on the ground, soaks clothing or bandages, or when the person shows shock or confusion. Act immediately.

- 1 Make the scene safe.** Do not enter traffic, fire, violence, electrical, structural, or other danger. Use disposable gloves and eye protection when available; do not delay lifesaving pressure if barriers are unavailable.
- 2 Activate help.** Call emergency services, or point to a person and tell them to call and bring a bleeding-control kit. Put the phone on speaker if you are alone.
- 3 Find and expose the injury.** Remove or cut clothing only as needed to see where blood is coming from. Check for more than one wound while protecting the person from cold.
- 4 Press continuously.** Place gauze or a clean dressing directly on the bleeding site. Push hard with both hands and hold steady until bleeding stops or responders take over. Do not lift the dressing to check; add material on top if needed.



Call → press → pack if trained → tourniquet for a severely bleeding limb. The sequence follows medically reviewed American College of Surgeons STOP THE BLEED training resources; this local adaptation still requires clinician or certified-instructor review.

Severe Bleeding Response — continued

IF DIRECT PRESSURE DOES NOT CONTROL IT

Pack an appropriate wound—only if trained

For a deep wound where a tourniquet cannot be used, such as the groin, armpit, shoulder, or neck, tightly pack bleeding-control gauze into the wound to the bleeding source, then press hard and continuously. Use hemostatic gauze if your training and product directions support it; otherwise use gauze from the bleeding-control kit. **Do not pack the chest, abdomen, or an eye.** Do not remove packing.

Use a commercial tourniquet for severe arm or leg bleeding

- 1 Place a recognized **commercial tourniquet** 2–3 inches (5–8 cm) above the bleeding wound, between the wound and torso. Do not place it over the wound or a joint. If the wound cannot be located quickly, place it high and tight on the limb.
- 2 Pull the strap tight and fasten it. Twist the windlass until bleeding stops, then secure the windlass. It will hurt. If bleeding continues, tighten further or apply a second commercial tourniquet above the first if available and you are trained.
- 3 Write the application time below and on the tourniquet if it has a time field. Keep it uncovered and visible. Stay with the person, keep them warm, and monitor breathing until responders arrive.

× DANGER — STOP NOW

Never remove an embedded object or probe a wound. Apply pressure around an embedded object. **Never** loosen, remove, or conceal an applied tourniquet; only emergency or medical professionals should remove it.

Equipment boundary: This handout recommends a recognized commercial tourniquet and purpose-made bleeding-control gauze. It does not teach or recommend improvised tourniquets or improvised wound-packing material.

RECORD AND HAND OVER

Responder information	Record
Tourniquet application time (include a.m./p.m.)	_____ : _____ a.m. / p.m.
Tourniquet location / number applied	_____
Other care given and changes observed	_____ _____
Care handed to (agency / responder)	_____
Handoff date and time	_____ : _____

Tell responders: where every wound is; when each tourniquet was applied; whether the wound was packed; what products were used; and any changes in breathing, alertness, or bleeding.

SOURCES

American College of Surgeons, *STOP THE BLEED Resources—Posters and Booklet* and *STOP THE BLEED Online Training*: www.stopthebleed.org/resources-poster-booklet/ and www.stopthebleed.org/training/online-course/. Accessed 2026-09-29.